

Reptile facts

Scaly and cold-blooded, reptiles first appeared around 310 million years ago and were the first backboned animals that could live entirely on land. From desert snakes to migrating sea turtles, reptiles today are scattered throughout the world, except the very coldest habitats.

WHAT IS A REPTILE?



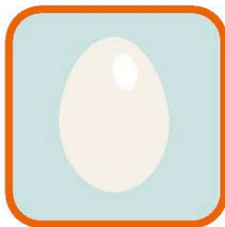
Vertebrates

From slithery snakes to giant tortoises, all reptiles are supported by a bony skeleton.



Cold-blooded

The body temperature of all reptiles changes depending on their environment.



Lay eggs

Most reptiles, from crocodiles to lizards, lay soft, leathery, and waterproof eggs.



Live young

Some snakes and lizards do not lay eggs like most other reptiles, but instead give birth to live young.

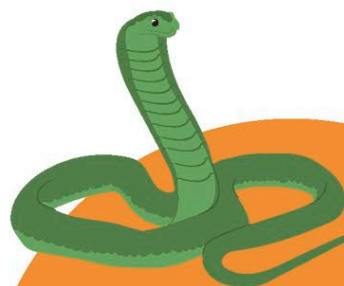


Scaly skin

Reptilian skin is covered in protective scales, or in some cases, horny plates.

REPTILE TYPES

ESTIMATED NUMBER OF REPTILE SPECIES: 11,340



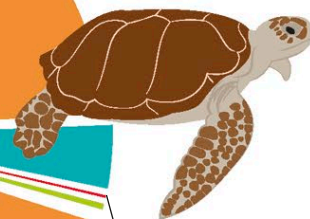
10,953

Lizards and snakes are the largest order of reptiles. They are found worldwide, but are more widespread in tropical or warmer climates.

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Turtles and tortoises

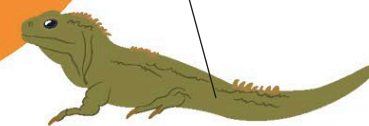
have domed shells that are fused to their spine and ribs. Tortoises live on land, while turtles live in oceans and fresh waters.



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Crocodylians

include crocodiles, alligators, and their relatives. They are the biggest and most formidable of all reptiles. They spend most of their time in water, although some hunt on land.



Tuatara is one of a kind, and lives in New Zealand. It is closely related to lizards, as it has small scales on its skin.

EXTREME HABITATS

From the freezing Arctic to underground burrows in the desert, some reptiles survive and thrive in the most incredible ways.



Common European adders are the only snake species found within the Arctic Circle. Its huge range also extends from temperate woodlands to the European Alps 9,840 ft (3,000 m) high.

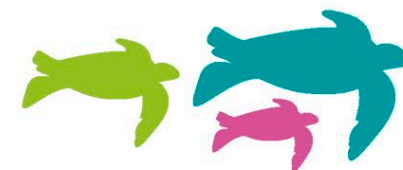


Gopher tortoises survive the intense heat and cold of the American Mojave Desert by burrowing underground with their sharp claws. They spend up to 95 percent of their lives in these burrows.



Sea snakes are the best-adapted reptile for life in water. All true sea snakes give birth to live young, without ever coming ashore to lay eggs. They live mainly in tropical oceans.

LONGEST MIGRATION



LEATHERBACK

TURTLES CAN TRAVEL

12,750 MILES

(20,500 KM) FROM THEIR

INDONESIAN BREEDING

GROUND TO FEED OFF THE

PACIFIC COAST OF THE USA.